to be switched off using one’s left hand. All this had to be done quickly and simultaneously. The second test was the Control Velocity Test. A small magnetic dot had to be superimposed on holes, which ran in two horizontal lines on a rotating drum, using a joystick.

After the briefing was over, the sergeant asked us if we were ready. I placed my hand on my chest number. I was reminded of Papaji’s words, ‘Four is your lucky number, Gunjan.’ He would often tell me when I was younger that he believed in numerology. The words had stuck, for some reason. I took a deep breath, held the joystick firmly, stared at the screen, narrowed my eyes and replied to the instructor, ‘I’m ready.’